BI AND REPORTING ANALYST

How I Handle Stakeholders

A method for getting decisions from incomplete data, under deadline

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THE METHOD

Six steps from request to decision

1

Clarify the decision

What will be decided, by whom, and by when.

2

Map the stakeholders

Who needs what, and who is affected.

3

Tailor each message

One clear headline for each audience.

4

Challenge the numbers

Check definitions and totals before anyone sees them.

5

Say what is unknown

Label gaps instead of filling them with guesses.

6

Close with clear asks

Specific decisions and specific data requests.

STEPS 1 AND 2

Map who needs what before writing anything

Stakeholder	What they need	What goes wrong if I miss it
Operations manager	One number to act on and clear decisions	The meeting debates the data instead of the decision
Leadership pack readers	Figures that hold up when someone asks how they were built	A challenged number undermines the whole pack
Data and policy owners	Missing timestamps and a confirmed late-delivery policy	The analysis stalls with no way to answer the real question

STEP 3

Tailor each message to its audience

For the decision maker

Lead with the headline rate, then the three decisions needed. Keep detail in supporting tables.

For the pack readers

Show that every table reconciles to the totals, and label each definition clearly.

For the data owners

Name the exact fields and the policy question. A specific request gets a faster answer than a general one.

STEP 4

Challenge the numbers before they are shown

Check the definition

Two definitions of late sat in one table: strict late (37,299) and five-minute late (17,968). I separated them and labelled each.

Check the totals

A column of rain-day figures matched the overall count exactly. I flagged it before any weather conclusion was drawn.

Check the claims

A draft said lateness could not be measured, but the data held both estimated and actual times. I corrected the claim and kept the grace period as the open question.

STEP 5

Say what is not yet known

Weather is not yet measured

The rain measure duplicated the overall count, so the report states that the impact is unknown rather than estimating it.

Cause is not proven

A preparation versus travel split needs timestamps the dataset does not hold. The report describes where lateness sits, not why.

Partial periods are labelled

Week 5 covers two days. It is marked as partial in every table and kept out of direct comparison with full weeks.

STEP 6

Close with clear asks

1. **Confirm the five-minute tolerance** as the official definition of late, or replace it.
2. **Approve the weekly validation**, with Week 5 shown as a two-day partial week.
3. **Agree the data request** for preparation, driver-arrival and handover timestamps.

HABITS I KEEP

What holds up under questions

1. Define the measure before showing a rate.
2. Reconcile every table to the totals.
3. Separate findings from hypotheses.
4. Ask for the specific data, not for more time.
5. Say plainly what is not known.